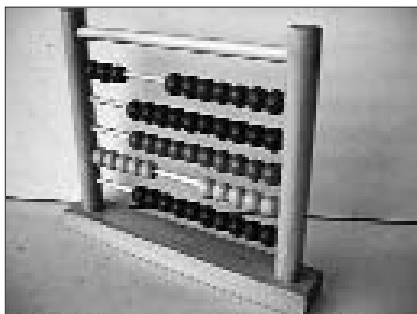


All the mechanical calculators that follow were invented in Europe: that's where scientific research blossomed at the time.

14??

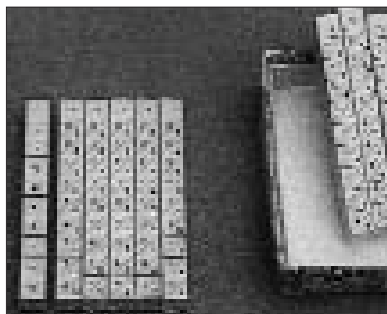
It appears Leonardo da Vinci had created a calculating machine; there seems to be a controversy about it, and it involves a Boston museum, so we can't really speak about this one; refer to www.webcom.com/calc/leonardo/leonardo.html if you're interested.



What was probably the first calculator!

1614

Scotsman and mathematician John Napier invented a system of moveable rods, referred to as Napier's Rods, which allowed for multiplication, division, and square and cube root calculation. The idea, vaguely put, was to move the rods and place them in boards of a certain construction. Well, that's as vague as it gets; visit www.cee.hw.ac.uk/~greg/calculators/napier/about.html.



Napier Rods—yet another milestone in the quest for manipulating numbers

1623

An interesting device was developed by Wilhelm Schickard who lived in Tübingen, Württemberg (which is now in Germany): it was called a "Calculating Clock." It was mechanical, naturally, and was capable of adding and subtracting six-digit numbers. It employed wheels for operations; one revolution of the "units" wheel incremented the "tens" wheel. You get the idea. What's especially interesting here is that